CHAPTER 1

Getting Started

We're going to spend a lot of time in this book talking about the Ruby language. Before we do, we want to make sure you can get Ruby installed and running on your computer. That way, you can try sample code and experiment on your own as you read along. If you want to learn Ruby you should get into the habit of writing code as you are reading.

If you are not comfortable with using a command line, we can help. Please turn to *Appendix 3, Command-Line Basics,* and we will give you all the information you need to get started.

Installing Ruby

There's a good chance your operating system already has Ruby installed. Try typing `ruby --version` at a command prompt—you may be pleasantly surprised. Likely, though, you'll find that the Ruby version is out of date. For example, as this is being written, macOS ships with Ruby 2.6.10, which is multiple versions behind the current Ruby.

The examples in this book are written against Ruby 3.2. While most of the code will work in older versions of Ruby, for performance and security reasons you should try to get on the most current version.

You can install Ruby in a variety of different ways, so providing general installation instructions becomes a little bit of a choose-your-own-adventure story. Most of the examples in this book assume you are using a Linux or Unix style system that responds to Linux-style commands. This includes all Linux distributions, macOS, Windows systems running Windows Subsystem for Linux (WSL)[1], and most Docker[2] containers as well as cloud-based development environments such as Replit.[3]

That said, Ruby does run on Windows. The process for managing a Ruby installation on Windows is different, and we'll cover it in full detail later in this chapter.

Please note that the tooling around Ruby installation does change frequently, and some of the specific instructions might be out of date, or replaced by newer tools.

1. https://docs.microsoft.com/en-us/windows/wsl/install
2. https://www.docker.com
3. https://replit.com